to prominence while he himself languished in neglect were a far simpler target of his loathing than the Padshah himself. On these men, and on all those like them, and on Akbar's Rajput wives, Badauni squarely put the blame for Akbar's wandering away from the path of orthodox Islam.

Perhaps even more provocative for thinkers like Badauni were signs that Akbar would not now tolerate anti-Shia behaviour. The previous year Mirza Fulad, 'a hot headed young man', and a Sunni, had murdered a Shia theologian, one Ahmad Thattawi. Ahmad Thattawi had been notoriously outspoken and 'was a firm adherent of the Imami doctrines, and talked largely about them, continually brought forward discourse about Sunnis and Shias, and from a despicable spirit used immoderate language'. Nonetheless, in the spirit of sulh kul, clarified Abu'l Fazl, 'every sect can assert its doctrine without apprehension and everyone can worship God after his own fashion'. Akbar had Mirza Fulad executed, despite the opposition from high-placed noblemen and even members of the harem, sending out a clear signal that he did not approve of such conflicts. As a result 'the contest between Sunni and Shia subsided'.

The deaths of Todar Mal and Bhagwant Das were grave losses for the Padshah, however. Bhagwant Das, especially, had been a staunch and unflinching ally since Akbar had been twenty years old. The raja had always responded with exemplary chivalry to the Padshah's frequent calls to demonstrate personal courage on the battlefield and Abu'l Fazl admitted that 'he was endowed with uprightness, weight of counsel, and courage' for which he had been rewarded by the high mansab of 5,000. Akbar had suffered a further loss on the trip to Kashmir when the intellectual and sadr, Shah Fathullah Shirazi, had died. Akbar was wont to say that the 'mir was his vakil, philosopher, physician and astronomer and that no one can understand the amount of his grief for him'. As for Raja Todar Mal, his personal seal reflected an entire cosmos of complicated loyalties, spelling out his allegiance to the two figures in his life, his God and his Emperor—Banda-i Dargha, Ram ki Panah (Servant of the Court and of God).

As the Mughal party made their slow way towards Lahore, tragedy and sorrow continued to stalk them. When hunting a hyena, Akbar was thrown from his horse and smashed his face on the rocky ground. Hakim Ali Gilani treated his wounds with a healing oil and, despite his courtiers advising against it, Akbar decided to continue the onward march in a litter. Then, in January 1590, Abu'l Fazl received the news that his mother had died in